EARLY READERS OUTREACH: A MINI-OPEN LIBRARY FOR CHILDREN AND TEENAGERS IN EWATTO, ESAN SOUTH EAST LGA, EDO STATE, NIGERIA

BY

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SECTION A: EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

1.1 Executive Summary

The Early Readers Outreach Mini-Library initiative aims to establish a sustainable community library in Ewatto, Esan South East LGA, Edo State, Nigeria, to address the lack of accessible reading materials and supportive learning spaces for children and adolescents. The community currently lacks standard library facilities, limiting young learners' access to books and educational resources — a key barrier to literacy development and lifelong learning.

This project will develop a fully equipped mini-library with age-appropriate books, reference materials, and literacy resources, and implement structured reading programs and outreach activities to foster a culture of reading. Through regular reading clubs, storytelling sessions, volunteer-led activities, and community engagement, the initiative will promote literacy proficiency, critical thinking, and educational participation among children and teens.

The initiative is closely aligned with the mission of National Literature Foundation, Nigeria (NLF), a non-governmental organization dedicated to improving human capital by providing books, reading rooms, and conducive library environments — particularly in disadvantaged communities — to encourage creativity, reading engagement, and academic success among children.

This proposal outlines a three-year implementation plan with clear targets, including expanded book collections, increased weekly participation in reading activities, measurable improvements in participants' literacy skills, and strengthened community ownership of the library. A robust monitoring and evaluation framework will track progress and outcomes to ensure the project's sustainability and impact.

By investing in the Early Readers Outreach Mini-Library, NLF has the opportunity to expand its impact to a community where ill-equipped educational resources currently limit children's academic potential. The project not only supports the foundation's vision of building reading culture but also contributes to broader education goals that empower youth through literacy and lifelong learning.

SECTION B: RATIONALE

2.1 Statement of Need

In the rural community of Ewatto, Esan South East Local Government Area, Edo State, Nigeria, children and adolescents continue to face significant barriers to literacy development and access to reading resources. A comprehensive survey of the community's information environment found that there were no standard libraries or information service centres of any type in Ewatto, including in local primary and secondary schools, leaving residents reliant on informal, oral or unreliable sources for information (Idiegbeyan-Ose et al., 2015).

While there has been some recent progress in educational infrastructure — including the establishment of the Equity Learning Academy (ELA), a tuition-free digital school serving students in Ewatto with technology-enabled instruction — this facility does not function as an open public library for the community at large and primarily serves enrolled pupils within its school context.

As such, there remains no proper, dedicated community space where children, teens, caregivers, and other residents can freely access a broad range of reading materials, reference resources, or supportive literacy programming.

The absence of a community library or reading hub limits opportunities for regular reading engagement, independent learning, and access to diverse books and informational resources outside of formal classroom settings. Research shows that access to books and library services supports reading proficiency, comprehension, and academic success, especially for children in rural settings where formal educational resources are limited (Ernst, 2023).

The Early Readers Outreach mini-library initiative seeks to address this gap by establishing a dedicated reading space equipped with books and learning materials in Ewatto. This project, aligning with the mission of National Literature Foundation, will enhance literacy outcomes, supplement formal education, and empower children and adolescents with foundational skills needed for academic success and lifelong learning (Tonegawa, 2022), contributing to both national educational goals and the *United Nations' Sustainable Development Goal 4 (Quality Education)*.

2.2 About National Literature Foundation

The National Literature Foundation (NLF) is a nonprofit organization committed to advancing literacy, promoting a culture of reading and expanding equitable access to books and learning resources. Modeled on the proven principles and approaches of the National Book Foundation, the Foundation works to strengthen educational outcomes and empower communities through sustained engagement with literature and learning.

2.2.1 Mission

The mission of the National Literature Foundation is to promote literacy and lifelong learning by increasing access to quality reading materials, supporting reading initiatives, and fostering inclusive literary engagement across all age groups and socio-economic backgrounds. Through targeted programs and partnerships, the Foundation seeks to remove barriers to reading and learning, particularly in underserved communities.

2.2.2 Vision

The National Literature Foundation envisions a literate society in which reading is a valued cultural practice, educational opportunities are equitably accessible, and individuals are empowered to reach their full potential through the written word. The Foundation believes that strong literacy skills are foundational to personal development, social inclusion, and national progress.

2.2.3 Objectives

In pursuit of its mission and vision, the National Literature Foundation is guided by the following core objectives:

- To expand access to books and literacy resources by supporting book distribution initiatives, community libraries, and affordable publishing models that make quality reading materials widely available.
- To promote reading engagement and literacy development through structured reading programs, community-based initiatives, and public literacy campaigns that encourage consistent reading habits.
- To support authors, educators, and literacy practitioners by providing platforms that amplify diverse voices and strengthen the broader literary and educational ecosystem.
- To advance educational equity by prioritizing children, youth, and adults in underserved and marginalized communities who face systemic barriers to literacy.
- To foster strategic partnerships with schools, libraries, civil society organizations, and public institutions to enhance program reach, sustainability, and impact.

SECTION C: PROJECT DESCRIPTION & METHODOLOGY

3.1 Project Description

The Early Readers Outreach Mini-Library initiative seeks to address the pervasive gap in access to reading resources and conducive learning spaces for children and adolescents in Ewatto, Esan South East LGA, Edo State, Nigeria. Currently, young learners in the community lack proper library facilities and access to quality books — conditions that significantly undermine literacy development and the cultivation of a reading culture. The project will establish a sustainable mini-library space equipped with age-appropriate books, educational resources, and structured reading activities to stimulate engagement and improve foundational literacy skills.

The underlying premise of this project is that access to reading resources and structured literacy support leads to increased participation in reading activities (outputs), which in turn enhances reading habits and comprehension skills (outcomes), ultimately contributing to improved educational attainment and a strengthened reading culture (impact). This causal chain is supported by evidence that improved access to books and reading spaces fosters reading engagement, language fluency, and learner confidence — outcomes that align with NLF's vision of transforming communities through literacy. (General literacy development research)

Assumptions:

- Parents and guardians will support their wards to utilize the library space.
- Facilitators and volunteers will sustain delivery of reading programs.
- Improved access to literacy resources contributes to measurable learning outcomes.

The target stakeholders include children and adolescents (primary beneficiaries), their parents and caregivers, educators, and community volunteers who will participate in program planning and delivery. Inclusive participation — especially gender-balanced engagement — is central to project planning to ensure equitable access and benefits for all youth.

3.2 Methodology

The project will be implemented using a results-focused approach that links activities with intended outputs and outcomes, guided by NLF's mission and best practices in community literacy programming.

3.2.1 Set-Up and Resource Preparation

Activities:

- Prepare a community reading space; furnish shelves, tables, seating.
- Procure and catalogue books, reference materials, and literacy supplies.

Outputs:

- Operational mini-library accessible to children and teens.
- Book inventory reflecting diverse reading levels and interests.

3.2.2 Structured Literacy Programming

Activities:

- Organize weekly reading clubs, storytelling sessions, and literacy workshops.
- Recruit and train community volunteers to support sessions.

Outputs:

- Participation records showing consistent engagement.
- Trained volunteers and facilitators supporting library activities.

Hypothesis: Regular, structured interaction with reading materials and peers will increase reading frequency, fluency, and enthusiasm among participants.

3.2.3 Monitoring and Adaptive Management

Activities:

- Track attendance, resource usage, and participant feedback.
- Conduct periodic assessments to measure reading progress.

Outputs:

- Data on user engagement and changes in reading proficiency.
- Reports informing improvement of programming.

Hypothesis: Monitoring data will help refine programming to better meet learners' needs and ensure continuous quality improvement.

3.2.4 Community Outreach and Sustainability

Activities:

- Engage parents, caregivers, and local leaders in events promoting reading.

- Establish systems for community volunteers to help sustain operations beyond the project period.

Outputs:

- Increased community awareness of literacy importance.
- Expanded volunteer participation.

Assumption: Sustained community involvement fosters ownership and continuity of library services.

3.3 Cross-Cutting Themes and Integration

The project addresses key cross-cutting themes important to NLF and responsible programming:

- **Rights-Based Approach:** The initiative recognizes **education and literacy as a fundamental right**, and the mini-library will be accessible to all children in the community regardless of gender, socioeconomic status, or ability. Programs will be designed to remove barriers to participation and ensure inclusive learning opportunities for boys and girls alike.
- **Gender Mainstreaming:** Activities and outreach will intentionally include both girls and boys, tracking gender-disaggregated participation to ensure equitable access and benefits.
- **Environmental Sensitivity and Sustainability:** Materials and infrastructure design will consider durability and low environmental impact. Where possible, local materials and community participation in maintenance will extend sustainability.

- **Sustainability of Results:** Training local volunteers and caregivers builds community capacity to sustain reading activities beyond the funding period. Engagement with schools and parents will support habit formation and long-term ownership.
- **Principled Humanitarian Approach:** Respect, dignity, and voluntary participation will underpin all engagements, ensuring that services respond to community needs and preferences in a culturally sensitive manner.

SECTION D: PROJECT GOAL AND OBJECTIVES

4.1 Project Goal

To establish a sustainable mini open library and reading hub in Ewatto (Esan South East LGA, Edo State) that fosters a culture of reading, enhances early literacy skills among children and teenagers, and strengthens community access to quality learning resources.

4.2 Specific Objectives

4.2.1. Improve access to reading materials

Outcome: Children and teens in Ewatto will have consistent access to age-appropriate books and learning resources that support literacy development and academic learning.

- Procure and curate a diverse collection of books for early readers, middle grade readers, and adolescents.
- Include reading materials that reflect local cultures, languages, and global perspectives.
- Establish accessible shelving and reading spaces designed for comfort and learning engagement.

4.2.2 Build a community literacy hub

Outcome: The mini open library will function as a community space that supports reading, learning, and positive youth engagement beyond the formal classroom.

- Create a safe, inclusive environment where children, teens, and caregivers can read, study, and share knowledge.
- Schedule regular reading hours, story sessions, and family reading events.

- Enable the space to serve as a resource for local educators, parents, and volunteers.

4.2.3 Strengthen reading culture and engagement

Outcome: Through targeted programming, the project will cultivate enthusiasm for reading and encourage lifelong literacy habits.

- Organize reading clubs segmented by age group (e.g., early readers, tweens, and teens).
- Facilitate literacy competitions, book discussions, and themed reading weeks.
- Provide recognition (certificates, small awards) to motivate participation and sustained reading.

4.2.4 Enhance literacy skills and educational support

Outcome: Children and teenagers participating in the project will demonstrate improved reading comprehension, vocabulary, and confidence in literacy skills.

- Offer reading support sessions and guided reading circles led by trained volunteers or educators.
- Track literacy progress through simple assessments and reading logs.
- Collaborate with local schools to align library-reading materials with academic learning goals.

4.2.5 Foster community ownership and sustainability

Outcome: The library will be locally supported and sustained through community engagement and participation.

- Recruit and train community volunteers to assist with library operations.
- Establish a local advisory committee (parents, teachers, youth leaders) to guide programming and ensure relevance.
- Develop a plan for material replenishment, community donations, and long-term resource growth.

4.2.6 Document impact and share best practices

Outcome: The project will generate meaningful data and insights to support scaling, replication, and advocacy.

- Record participation, feedback, and literacy growth data.
- Produce short reports or case studies to share with NLF and potential partners.
- Highlight success stories to promote *reading culture* and engage future supporters.

4.3 Alignment with National Literature Foundation's Mission

The *Early Readers Outreach* project directly supports NLF's strategic objectives by:

- Expanding access to books and reading spaces in underserved communities.
- Promoting reading culture among children and youth, key target groups in nlf's work.
- Creating a community-based model that can be adapted or scaled to other rural areas.
- Strengthening educational outcomes through both access and active engagement with reading.

This project builds on NLF's commitment to transforming lives through literacy, education, and community learning, and serves as a catalytic initiative to demonstrate measurable improvements in reading habits and community empowerment.

SECTION E: BUGDET AND RESOURCE PLAN

5.1 Project Budget — Early Readers Outreach Mini-Library (First Year)

Budget Category	Description	Amount (NGN)
1. Infrastructure & Setup		
Facility preparation	Painting, shelving installation, minor repairs	300,000
Furniture & fixtures	Tables, chairs, kids seating, shelves	250,000
Library signage	Branding + welcome signs	50,000
Office supplies & cataloging setup	Records, labels, forms	70,000
Subtotal 1		**670,000**
2. Collections & Resources		
Children & teen books	Diverse titles for reading and academics	500,000
Reference materials	Dictionaries, learning kits, educational sets	150,000
Reading program materials	Storytelling kits, supplies for activities	80,000
Subtotal 2		**730,000**
3. Human Resources & Training		
Library facilitator (12 months)	Part-time facilitator to manage the library	1,800,000
Volunteer stipends	Monthly stipends for assistants	300,000
Staff training & development	Capacity building for service delivery	120,000
Subtotal 3		**2,220,000**
4. Operations & Programming		
Reading clubs & activities	Supplies + incentives for programs	200,000
Community outreach events	School visits, awareness campaigns	150,000
Utilities	Electricity, internet, cleaning supplies	180,000
Marketing & awareness	Flyers, community announcements	80,000
Subtotal 4		**610,000**
5. Contingency (10%)	**Buffer for price changes & unforeseen expenses**	**423,000**
Grand Total	All categories combined	4,633,000

5.2 Budget Justification

5.2.1 Infrastructure & Setup (₦670,000)

The mini-library needs a safe, welcoming physical space to operate. Facility preparation – including painting, shelves, and repairs – ensures the environment is functional and inviting for children. Furniture and shelving create dedicated spaces for reading and storing materials. Signage and initial cataloging supplies support ease of use and organisational efficiency. These one-time setup costs are essential before any reading programs can begin.

5.2.2 Collections & Resources (₦730,000)

Books and reference materials are the core of the literacy initiative. A diverse collection of age-appropriate titles helps engage learners of different reading levels and interests. Reference materials (like dictionaries and learning kits) support academic learning and comprehension, while program materials enhance reading club activities and storytelling sessions, directly contributing to literacy outcomes.

5.2.3 Human Resources & Training (₦2,220,000)

A facilitator is critical for running daily library operations, assisting users, organizing programs, and managing volunteers. Stipends for volunteer assistants help maintain consistent support and encourage community ownership. Training ensures staff and volunteers are equipped to manage collections, engage young readers, and deliver programs effectively — a fundamental investment for project sustainability.

5.2.4 Operations & Programming (₦610,000)

Ongoing costs include materials for weekly reading clubs, community outreach events to raise awareness and encourage participation, utilities (electricity and internet) to keep the space functional, and marketing to inform the community about services. These operational expenses ensure the library remains active, accessible, and impactful throughout the first year.

5.2.5 Contingency (₦423,000)

A contingency buffer (about 10%) is included to accommodate price fluctuations or unexpected needs — a standard practice in budgeting that helps maintain project continuity without jeopardizing activities.

5.3 Multi Year Budget – Years 2 and 3

S/N	Budget Category	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
1.	Infrastructure & Setup	670,000	—	—
2.	Collections & Resources	730,000	770,000	810,000
3.	Human Resources & Training	2,220,000	2,330,000	2,450,000
4.	Operations & Programming	610,000	640,000	670,000
5.	Contingency (10%)	423,000	476,000	493,000
	Total Estimated Budget	**4,633,000**	**4,216,000**	**4,423,000**

5.3.1 Multi-Year Budget Narrative

The projected budgets for Years 2 and 3 reflect modest increases in recurring costs (approximately 3–5 % annually) to account for inflation and expected cost escalation in personnel, program supplies, utilities, and other operational expenses. This approach ensures that

the project remains realistic and able to meet service demands despite changes in the cost of goods and services, which often rise over time. For example, increases in material and wage costs can affect how far a fixed budget goes from year to year, and planning for this helps maintain program quality and continuity.

A contingency allocation is included in each year's budget to provide a financial buffer for unforeseen expenses or minor changes in cost trends. Contingency funds help the project adapt to unexpected situations — such as sudden price increases or unanticipated needs — without compromising planned activities or outcomes.

SECTION F: EXPECTED IMPACT

6.1 Year One Evaluation

S/N	Objective	Indicator	Target	Data Source / Method	Frequency
1.	Access to reading materials	Number of books available in library	800+ books by end of Year 1	Catalog inventory	Quarterly
2.	Community engagement	Number of children/teens attending weekly	100+ participants per month	Attendance register	Monthly
3.	Reading culture	Number of reading club sessions held	24 sessions/year	Activity logs	Quarterly
4.	Literacy improvement	% of participants improving reading levels	70% improvement after 6 months	Pre/post literacy assessments	Mid & End of Year
5.	Sustainability	Number of active community volunteers trained	10+ volunteers	Volunteer records	Annual
6.	Stakeholder satisfaction	% of positive feedback from users	80% satisfaction	Feedback surveys	Biannual
7.	Gender & inclusion	% of girls and boys attending sessions	Balanced participation	Attendance records	Quarterly

6.2 Multi-Year Evaluation

S/N	M&E Component	Year 1 (Set-Up & Launch)	Year 2 (Consolidation)	Year 3 (Impact & Sustainability)
1.	Baseline Data Collection	Conduct at start	—	—
2.	Routine Monitoring	Monthly tracking of participation and outputs	Monthly tracking + quarterly reports	Monthly tracking + mid-year and end-year reports
3.	Reading Skill Assessments	Pre-program assessment	Mid-year reassessment	Endline assessment
4.	Stakeholder Feedback	End of Year feedback surveys	Mid-year & end-year surveys	Mid-year & final surveys
5.	Participatory Evaluation Sessions	One at year's end	One mid-year & year's end	Comprehensive final review with community
6.	Data Review Meetings	Quarterly with staff	Quarterly with staff + stakeholders	Semi-annual with staff + stakeholders

CONCLUSION

The Early Readers Outreach Mini-Library initiative offers a practical and sustainable solution to the lack of accessible reading resources and library infrastructure for children and adolescents in Ewatto, Esan South East LGA, Edo State. By creating a community-based library equipped with quality books, structured reading programs, and volunteer-supported activities, this project will foster a culture of reading, strengthen literacy skills, and empower young learners to succeed academically and socially — outcomes that align closely with NLF's mission to improve access to books, reading environments, and lifelong learning opportunities for disadvantaged children.

We respectfully invite National Literature Foundation, Nigeria (NLF) to collaborate with us in implementing this initiative. Your support — whether through funding, technical guidance, resource provision, or capacity building — will make a meaningful difference in the educational experiences of Ewatto's children, helping bridge the literacy gap and create lasting impact in the community.

For further information or to discuss partnership opportunities, please contact:

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We look forward to the opportunity to collaborate with National Literature Foundation and welcome the chance to provide additional information or clarifications upon request.

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